

MONEY THAT MAKES SENSE

A Simple Way to Manage Money When Your Income Isn't Steady

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This book is meant to help you think more clearly about your money. It is not professional financial advice, so please speak with a qualified advisor about your own situation.

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Introduction

Why Your Money Feels Different

If you've ever picked up a budgeting book and given up on it within a few weeks, I think I know why. Almost every book about money assumes you get paid the same amount, on the same day, every single month. It assumes a steady salary.

But that's just not how a lot of us live. Maybe you freelance. Maybe you sell things online, or run a small shop, or take on work as it comes. Maybe you have one steady thing and a few side things that fill in the gaps. Whatever your situation looks like, your income moves. Some months are good, some are lean, and no spreadsheet built for a nine to five salary is ever going to fit your life properly.

This book isn't about getting rich quickly, and it isn't going to guilt you into cutting out the small things you enjoy. It's about building a simple, honest way of handling money that works with how it actually reaches you, not how someone else assumes it should.

We'll take this step by step. You don't need to be good with numbers, and you don't need any background in finance. You just need to be willing to look at your money clearly and build a few small habits that hold up even when a slow month comes along, because it will. That's exactly what this book is here to help you handle.

Chapter 1

Why Normal Budgeting Doesn't Work For You

Most budgeting advice follows the same pattern. Work out your monthly income, split it into categories, and stick to the plan. It sounds simple enough, but it falls apart completely if your income changes by thirty, fifty, even a hundred percent from one month to the next.

Here's the real issue. That kind of budget isn't wrong, it's just answering a question you don't actually have. It assumes the amount coming in stays the same, and the only thing that changes is how you spend it. For you, the amount itself is what changes, and that changes everything about how a plan needs to work.

When someone with an irregular income tries to force themselves into a fixed budget, one of two things usually happens. Either they build the plan around a good month, then feel like a failure the moment a slow month arrives and quietly give up. Or they build it around a bad month, and end up feeling unnecessarily tight every time a good month comes along and they don't quite know what to do with the extra.

None of that is your fault. The tool simply wasn't built for your kind of income. What you need instead is a plan with two settings, one for when money is flowing and one for when it isn't, with a calm, clear way of moving between the two. That's exactly what we'll build together in the chapters ahead.

Chapter 2

Knowing Your Real Number

Before you can plan anything properly, you need two numbers, not one. Most people only ever work out one figure, how much they need to live. But if your income moves around, you actually need to know two separate amounts: your survival number and your comfort number.

Your survival number is the smallest amount it takes to keep your life running for a month. Rent, food, transport, the essential bills, nothing extra. This is the number that matters most in a slow month. It isn't about living well, it's simply about not falling behind.

Your comfort number is what it costs to live the way you actually want to. A bit of breathing room, some consistent saving, and the feeling that you're doing more than just scraping by. This is the number to aim for in a normal or good month.

Take twenty minutes this week and write both numbers down properly. Not a rough guess, go through your bank statements or notes if you can, and get as close to accurate as possible. Most people are surprised at how much lower their real survival number is than they assumed, and that alone brings a good amount of relief.

- Survival number: what keeps everything running, nothing more
- Comfort number: what a genuinely good month costs you
- Write both down somewhere you'll actually see again

Chapter 3

The Good Month, Bad Month System

Once you know your two numbers, you can build the heart of this whole approach. Treat every month as either a good month or a bad month, and have a different plan already decided for each one.

A bad month is any month where your income comes in at or below your survival number. In a bad month, the rule is simple. Cover the essentials, pause every spend that isn't necessary, and leave your savings alone unless it's a genuine emergency. There's no shame in this. It's the plan working exactly the way it was meant to.

A good month is any month where income comes in above your comfort number. In a good month, resist the urge to spend it all simply because it's there. Instead, follow a simple split. Some goes into your buffer, which we'll cover next, some goes toward goals or debt, and a portion, guilt free, goes toward actually enjoying your life.

The strength of this system isn't that it's clever, it's that the decision is already made long before the month even starts. You're not negotiating with yourself the moment money gets tight, and you're not making excited, impulsive choices the moment things are good. You already know what a good month and a bad month mean for you, and exactly what to do in each one.

Chapter 4

Building a Buffer Without a Steady Paycheck

A buffer is money set aside for one specific job, closing the gap between a bad month and your survival number. It's the single most important thing you can build if your income moves around, more important right now than investing or aggressive saving.

Over time, the goal is to build a buffer that could cover at least one full bad month at your survival number. That might feel far away today, and that's completely okay. It's built slowly, a little at a time, mostly during the good months.

Here's a simple rule to follow. Every good month, before anything else, move a fixed percentage, even just ten percent, into a separate account you don't touch for everyday spending. It doesn't need a special app or a complicated setup. A second account that isn't linked to your daily debit card is usually enough to keep it untouched.

Don't wait until you feel like you have extra to start this. There will always be a reason to spend whatever feels extra. The buffer only gets built if it's the first thing that happens in a good month, not whatever's left over at the end.

Chapter 5

Paying Yourself First, Even When It's Unpredictable

You've probably heard the phrase pay yourself first. Save before you spend, rather than saving whatever happens to be left over. It's good advice, but when your income doesn't arrive on any kind of schedule, the word first needs to mean something slightly different.

For you, first isn't about timing within the month, it's about timing within each payment. The moment money reaches you, before it touches everyday spending, a portion of it moves toward your buffer or your goals. Not at the end of the week, not whatever's left, but the moment it lands.

This matters even more with irregular income, not less, because there's no guaranteed next paycheck waiting to catch you if you skip it this time. The money in front of you right now might be the only money you see for a while, so it's worth treating every payment with that kind of respect, however small or large it is.

A simple place to start. For every payment you receive, set aside a fixed percentage straight away, even just five percent to begin with, before you do anything else with it. Automate it if your bank allows that. If not, make it a personal rule you follow without exception.

Chapter 6

Debt and Irregular Income

Debt is stressful for anyone, but it carries its own particular weight when your income isn't steady, because a payment that felt easy in a good month can suddenly feel impossible in a slow one.

If you're dealing with debt, the first step is to get clear on which kind you're facing. Fixed payment debt, like a loan with a set monthly amount, needs to sit inside your survival number. It comes out no matter what. Flexible debt, like money owed informally or a balance you're paying down at your own pace, has more room to move in a bad month.

Where you can, talk to whoever you owe money to before a payment gets missed, not after. Most lenders, even informal ones, respond far better to this month is tight, can we adjust something than to silence followed by a missed payment. Speaking up early isn't weakness, it's exactly the kind of habit this whole book is trying to help you build.

And where possible, try not to take on new fixed payment debt just because a good month made the money feel available. A good month is temporary by nature when your income is irregular, so try not to let a temporary high turn into a permanent monthly obligation.

Chapter 7

Saving For Something Big Without a Fixed Timeline

Saving for something big, a deposit, equipment for your work, a major life event, usually comes with advice like save this much every month for this many months. That formula assumes steady income. Yours calls for something a little different, saving by percentage instead of by date.

Rather than committing to a fixed monthly amount, commit to a fixed percentage of every good month's surplus, say twenty percent, that goes straight toward this one goal, kept separate from your everyday buffer. In a slow month, that percentage might be zero, and that's fine. In a great month, it could be a lot.

This takes away the guilt of falling behind a schedule that was never realistic for you in the first place. Your goal still gets funded, just in the rhythm your income actually allows, rather than one borrowed from someone else's life.

Give the goal a name, and if you can, a place of its own. A labelled envelope, a separate savings pocket, anything that makes it feel distinct from your regular buffer. Watching it grow, even unevenly, keeps it real and worth continuing to fund.

Chapter 8

What To Do The Moment Money Comes In

This chapter is short on purpose, because having one clear, repeatable sequence for the moment money lands takes away most of the stress and second guessing that usually comes with irregular income.

Here's a simple order to follow every time you get paid, whatever the amount.

- First, set aside your buffer or goal percentage straight away
- Then, cover any fixed payments that are due
- Next, cover your survival essentials for the period this payment needs to stretch across
- Only once those are handled, spend the rest freely and without guilt

The exact percentages are yours to decide, based on everything we've covered so far. What matters is that the order stays the same every single time. That consistency is what makes an irregular income feel manageable, even when the amount itself never quite is.

Chapter 9

Handling the Fear That Comes With Slow Months

No system fully takes away the emotional weight of a slow month, and it's worth saying that plainly rather than pretending a good plan makes the fear disappear. When money is tight, it's completely natural to feel anxious, even when you've done everything right.

What a good system gives you is somewhere for that fear to land. Instead of spiralling into thoughts like what if this never gets better, you can ask a much smaller, more answerable question. Do I have enough in my buffer to cover this month at my survival number? If the answer is yes, you already know what to do, because you built this plan for exactly this moment.

If the answer is no, that's useful too. It simply tells you the buffer needs a little more attention next time things are good, not that the whole approach has failed. A slow month is information, not a verdict on your worth or your effort.

Try, as much as you can, to separate the practical response from the emotional one. What does the plan say to do, and how does this month actually make you feel. Both are real and valid, but only one of them needs to be the one driving your decisions.

Chapter 10

A Monthly Money Check In You'll Actually Keep

Every system eventually falls apart without a simple habit of checking in on it, and most people abandon these check ins because they make them far too long, too detailed, or too hard on themselves.

Here's a check in built to take about fifteen minutes, once a month, that you'll genuinely keep doing.

- Was this a good month or a bad month, by your own definition
- Did you follow the order from Chapter 8 for each payment that came in
- How much did your buffer grow or shrink this month
- Is there one small thing worth adjusting next month, just one, not ten

That's really all it takes. No spreadsheet with fifteen categories, no harsh scoring of yourself. The point of this check in isn't perfection, it's staying in an honest, ongoing conversation with your own money, one small adjustment at a time.

Conclusion

Money That Makes Sense For Your Life

If there's one thing to take from this book, let it be this. You don't need a steadier income to feel steady about money. You need a system that was actually built for the income you have, not the income someone else assumed you should have.

Nothing in this book asks you to earn more right away, though it may well help you get there over time. It simply asks you to know your numbers, decide your rules ahead of time, and follow the same small sequence every time money arrives, whether it's a good month or a slow one.

Start small. Pick just one idea from this book, even the good month, bad month split from Chapter 3, and put it into practice this month. You don't need the whole system running perfectly from day one. You just need to start treating your money in a way that actually makes sense for how it reaches you.

Thank you for reading. If this book helped you see your money a little more clearly, then it's already done exactly what it set out to do.